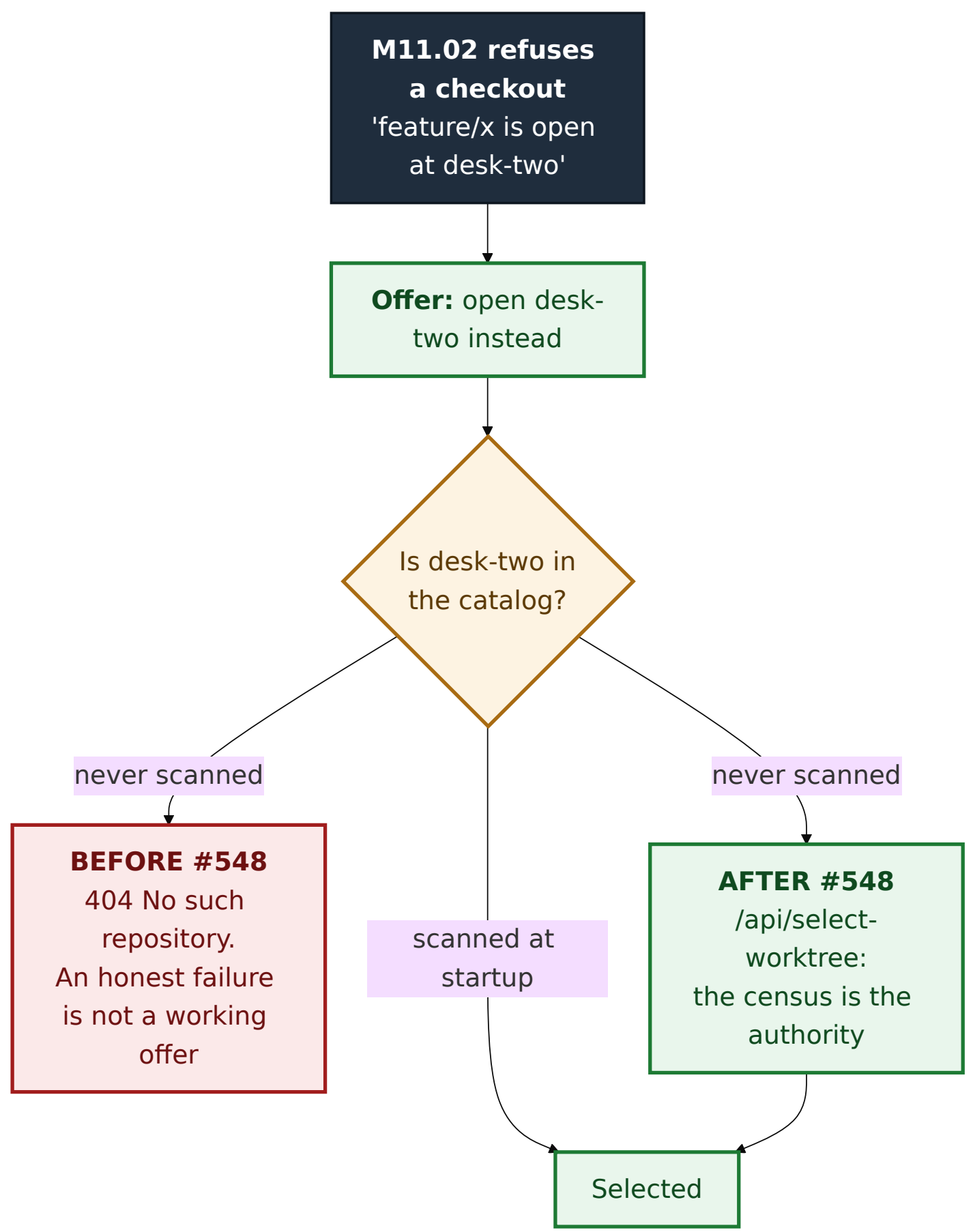


ADR 0117 — A discovered desk needs a door, and the door does not move the fence

- **Status:** Accepted — implemented, mutation-proved three ways failing at disjoint assertions, browser-verified
- **Date:** 2026-09-04
- **Issue:** #548 (M11.03)
- **Extends:** [ADR 0116](#) (whose refusal this turns into a route) · [ADR 0092](#) · [ADR 0115](#)
- **Supersedes / superseded by:** —

Context

M11.02 taught the app to refuse a checkout git would reject and to *name the worktree holding the branch*. That sentence was a route with nowhere to go. `POST /api/select` resolves ids through the catalog and answers `404` for anything it does not already hold — and a linked worktree nobody ever scanned is not in it. So the "open that worktree instead" offer failed on a perfectly serviceable desk. #651's own PR body named the gap and deferred it here.



Decision

1. A second door, because the two routes differ in what authorises an id

`/api/select` 's fail-closed `404` is correct and is **not** changed. Teaching it to fall back to a filesystem walk would turn an unknown id from "refused, nothing happened" into "scan the disk and see" — a security-relevant loosening of a well-tested route, applied to every caller of it.

route	authority	unknown id
<code>/api/select</code>	the catalog	<code>404</code> , and nothing is scanned
<code>/api/select-worktree</code>	a fresh census of the served repository	<code>404</code> unless that census names it

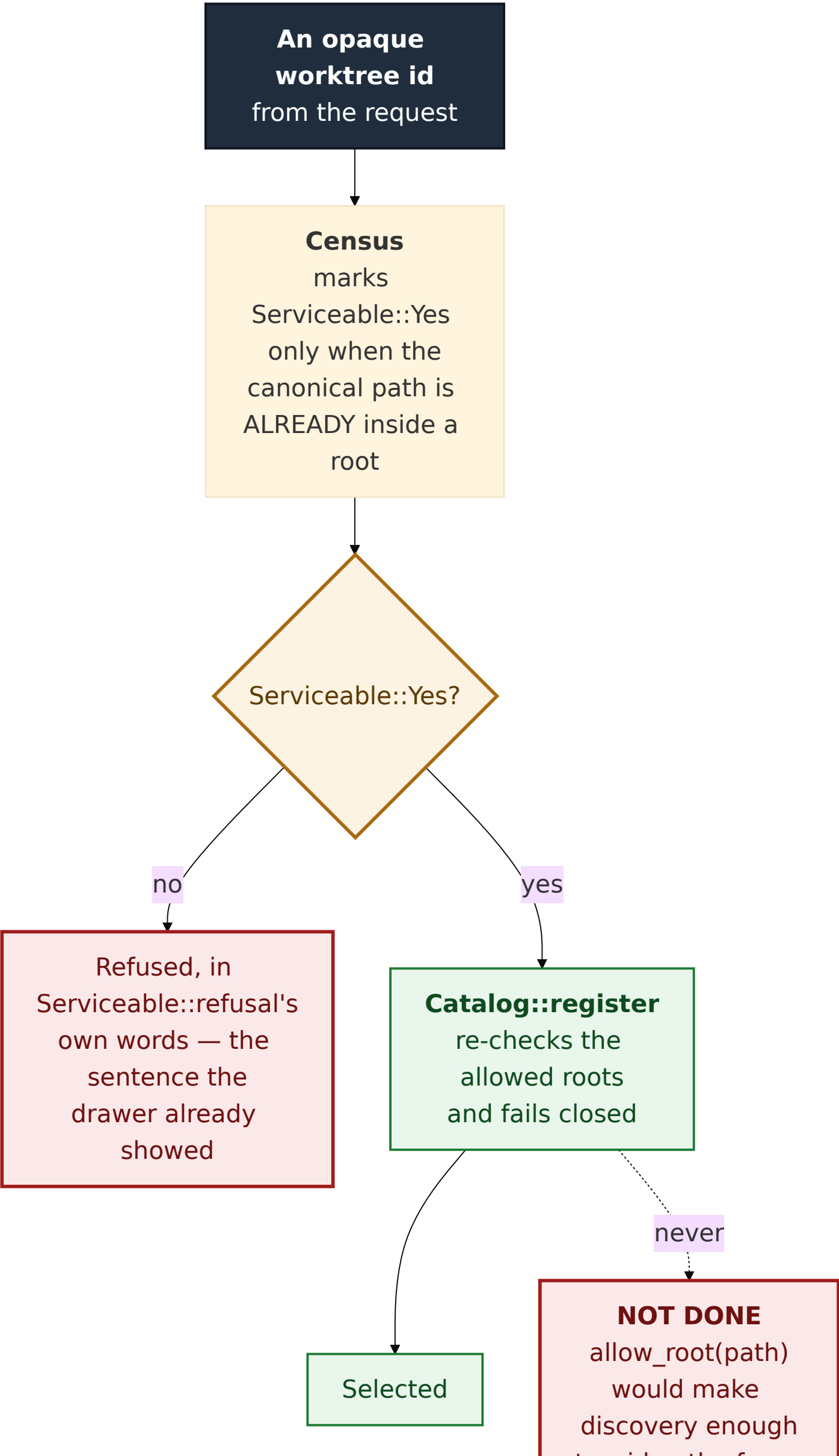
The catalog is still asked **first**, so the common case on this machine — where the repo-root scan already registered every worktree under `~/projects` — costs no subprocess and reuses the existing path verbatim.

2. The fence is enforced twice, and admitting never widens it

This is the decision the ADR exists for.

`register_explicit` allows a root and *then* registers under it, which is right for a path an operator named on the command line. Doing the same for a discovered worktree would make "git listed this directory" sufficient to widen the fence — and `git worktree add` would become a way to make this app serve any directory on the filesystem. That is the second of the three options `docs/superpowers/specs/m3.23-worktrees.md` §1 weighs, and the one it rejects.

So `register_discovered_worktree` calls `Catalog::register` and **deliberately does not call `allow_root`**:



The guarantee is an omission, and an omission has no runtime signature. Adding `allow_root` makes the app serve *more*, never less: no behavioural test goes red, nothing looks wrong, and the fence is gone. It is therefore pinned by reading the source — `admitting_a_discovered_worktree_never_widens_the_allowed_roots` — with a paired positive asserting that the `register` it calls is still the one that refuses an outside path.

2a. `expose_paths: true` on the internal census — what it does and does not disclose

The handler takes its census with `expose_paths: true` because registration takes a path and the handler has to have one. The question that makes that acceptable is narrower than "is anything disclosed": it is **does census output need redacting before it reaches a client?** Answered honestly, in two halves, because the two halves have different answers.

On the success path, no. An `Observed` census's `WorktreeSibling::path` is read locally and never serialized: this handler answers with a status and a sentence it composes itself, and no sibling row reaches the response. So `expose_paths: true` here discloses nothing that the operator's `GIT_VISTA_EXPOSE_PATHS` opt-in would otherwise have withheld.

On the failure path, yes — and this ADR previously said otherwise. A

`WorktreeCensus::CensusFailed { reason }` is answered as `Couldn't read this repository's worktrees, so nothing was selected: {reason}`, and those reasons are built in `worktree_census` from porcelain output and `common_dir.display()`. That is an absolute path in a response body. The original sentence here — *"nothing from that census is serialized to the client"* — was true of `Observed` and false of `CensusFailed`, and it was stated as though it covered both (found by Grok, round 6, finding 4).

Two facts bound the size of that, and neither excuses the wrong sentence:

- It is **not introduced by this route.** `GET /api/worktrees` (M11.01, #546) already returns `CensusFailed.reason` verbatim, and does so **with** `expose_paths` **off** — the failure arm never consulted the flag.
- The audience is an authenticated session on the loopback-only router, and the paths are the operator's own.

So the real defect is a contract one, not a leak to a stranger: `GIT_VISTA_EXPOSE_PATHS` is the control whose stated guarantee is that absolute paths do not leave the process unless the operator opts in, and the census's failure arm makes that guarantee untrue as stated. A control that is right on the path everyone tests and wrong on the path nobody does is the shape worth naming.

This ADR deliberately does not fix it, because the fix is a real trade-off and belongs to whoever weighs it rather than to a slice about something else. A `CensusFailed` reason is *how you find out why enumeration failed*; redacting paths out of it costs exactly the diagnosability it exists for. The two shapes worth considering — strip paths from the reason, or split it into a client-safe summary plus a server-only detail — are a change to M11.01's wire contract, not to this route. **Tracked as #657**, so the open question lives somewhere it can be answered rather than only in a paragraph of a decision record about something else.

3. Three facts on a row, and they stay three

`locked / prunable / bare` are **git's**. `Serviceable` is **this application's**. The offer is derived from both. #548 names the collapse as a failure condition, and the sharpest consequence is concrete: a locked worktree inside the allowed roots is still openable — locking only stops `git worktree remove / prune` — so one "unusable" badge would make that row unopenable for a reason nobody holds.

They render through `.act-pill.act-terminal` and `.act-pill.act-app`, an existing pair whose documented meaning is already *"done outside git-vista"* versus *"done through it"*. Reusing it gives two visibly different colours with no new CSS rule, no new `:focus-visible` twin, and no new

`INTERACTIVE_CENSUS` row. The browser leg asserts the two **computed colours** differ, not only the class names — two classes resolving to the same colour would satisfy a structural check and fail the criterion.

4. A refusal is text, and the text has one source

`Serviceable::refusal` lives in the protocol crate and is used by **both** the server's `409` and the drawer's row. Two copies would let the drawer promise one thing and the server say another about the identical row — and the drawer's copy is the one a user reads while deciding whether to tap at all.

It is rendered as a paragraph, never `title=`: #65's finding is that a tooltip-only reason never surfaces on a tap and is never announced. The stash drawer beside this one *does* use `title=`, so "follow the neighbouring file" would have reintroduced the defect; the view's own doc says so, and a source census asserts the refused arm carries no `title=`.

Alternatives considered

- **Widen `/api/select` to fall back to a census.** Rejected: it changes what an unknown id means for every existing caller, and the fail-closed `404` is a tested security property.
- **Register every discovered sibling during the census.** Rejected: the census is a *read*, called from the planner on every checkout plan. A read with a registration side effect is a different thing wearing a read's name.
- **Hide the desks this app cannot open.** Rejected by the spec, and it would also make the drawer disagree with M11.02's collision check, which counts every worktree git counts.
- **Grey the refused rows out.** This is the failure the milestone exists to correct: a disabled control with no explanation teaches nothing.
- **A new `overlay` variant for the drawer.** Rejected: the stash drawer's precedent — a section of the Activity panel — needs no new overlay vocabulary, no new dock rule, and no new CSS.

Consequences

- One new POST route, classified in `ROUTE_AUTHZ` (`SessionAndCsrf`) and in the planner's write-route census as a **catalog write, not a git write** — it mints no plan and touches no ref, so it has no funnel row.
- `Serviceable` gains user-facing text, so the protocol crate now owns a sentence the browser suite asserts on. That is deliberate: the alternative is the same sentence in two crates.
- The drawer refetches on the graph epoch and only while the Activity panel is open, so a closed panel costs nothing.
- **The browser leg is not optional here and was not treated as such.** #547 shipped with its dialog path unexecuted, flagged honestly in its PR body. This feature is a real drawer, so it gets five real browser tests — including the end-to-end switch to a desk the catalog never held, which is the only place the gap this ADR closes can actually be observed closing.

Mutation proof

Three arms, all `caught`, at **disjoint** assertions in two crates:

arm	mutation	assertion red
hide what we cannot open	<code>drawer_view</code> filters out non-serviceable siblings	<code>every_sibling_is_listed_including_the_ones_the_app_refuse</code> <code>["here","desk-two"]</code> vs <code>["here","desk-two","outside","ghos</code>
widen the fence	<code>register_discovered_worktree</code> calls <code>allow_root</code> before registering	<code>admitting_a_discovered_worktree_never_widens_the_allowed_</code> — a different crate, and the only arm any of these tests can catch, because the defect makes the app serve <i>more</i>
one badge for both	<code>app_fact</code> collapses the two refusals to <code>"unusable"</code> and reports <code>FactSource::Git</code>	<code>the_three_app_verdicts_are_three_different_sentences</code> — <code>["open","unusable","unusable"]</code> , plus <code>a_locked_worktree_inside_the_roots_is_still_openable</code>

The second arm is the one worth restating. It is a pure widening: every behavioural test in this repository still passes under it, the app still works, and every worktree still opens. Only a test that reads the source can see it, which is why the guarantee is written down as an omission and checked as one.